

Section 8 Landlord Complete Checklist

Full lifecycle — deal analysis, PHA registration, NSPIRE inspection prep (room-by-room), tenant placement, RFTA, HAP contract, move-in documentation, and annual re-inspection. 115+ action items across 6 phases.

Used by BRRRR8 Academy students across 14+ states · brrrr8academy.com

PHASE 1 — BEFORE YOU BUY

STEP 1 — MARKET & DEAL ANALYSIS

- ☐ **Look up the HUD Fair Market Rent for your target zip code and bedroom size**
huduser.gov/portal/datasets/fmr.html — this is your Section 8 rent ceiling; confirm before making any offer
- ☐ **Confirm your local PHA is actively issuing Housing Choice Vouchers**
 Call or email the PHA: "Are you currently issuing vouchers and accepting new landlord registrations?"
- ☐ **Confirm PHA is accepting new landlord applications**
 Some PHAs have temporary pauses or waiting periods for new landlords — verify before closing
- ☐ **Run full deal numbers: purchase + rehab, ARV, Section 8 rent, PITI + vacancy + reserves**
 Use the BRRRR8 Academy Deal Analyzer — must produce positive cash flow after all expenses
- ☐ **Check zoning compliance — property must be legal residential use in that jurisdiction**
 Confirm SFR vs. multi-family classification; some HOAs also restrict rental activity
- ☐ **Check property for lead paint exposure risk (any pre-1978 construction)**
 Lead paint disclosure is federally required; PHA may require full remediation under EPA RRP rules
- ☐ **Run a preliminary title search — look for liens, back taxes, and ownership disputes**
 Mechanic liens, unpaid taxes, or judgment liens become your responsibility at closing
- ☐ **Verify the property has active utility service available (gas, electric, water/sewer)**
 Properties on well/septic need PHA approval; confirm electric and gas providers serve the address

PHASE 2 — PHA REGISTRATION

STEP 2 — REGISTER WITH YOUR LOCAL PHA

- ☐ **Find your local PHA contact information**
hud.gov/program_offices/public_indian_housing/programs/hcv/ click "PHA Contact Info"
- ☐ **Download or request the landlord registration/onboarding packet from your PHA**
 Many PHAs have online portals; some require in-person visits or notarized documents
- ☐ **Complete and submit the landlord / property owner application**
 Provide your full legal name, business entity (LLC or personal), mailing address, and contact info
- ☐ **Provide government-issued photo ID**
 Driver's license or passport required for identity verification — make a clean copy
- ☐ **Provide proof of property ownership**
 Recorded deed, title commitment, or county assessor/tax record showing your name on the property

☐ **Provide proof of current property insurance**
Landlord or dwelling fire policy — most PHAs require minimum \$100,000 liability; confirm exact amount

☐ **Complete and submit a W-9 form (IRS Request for Taxpayer Identification)**
Required by PHA for HAP payment processing and year-end 1099-MISC reporting

☐ **Set up ACH direct deposit for Housing Assistance Payment (HAP)**
PHA needs your bank name, routing number, account number, or a voided check

☐ **Register the property address in the PHA landlord portal (if applicable)**
Some PHAs require each individual property to be registered separately — ask during enrollment

☐ **Request the current Payment Standard schedule for your zip code and bedroom sizes**
Payment Standard = the maximum HAP for each bedroom count in your area — your rent cannot exceed it

☐ **Ask PHA: average time from RFTA submission to first HAP payment**
Typical range is 30–60 days; budget your carry costs and holding expenses for this window

☐ **Ask PHA: any special requirements for this property address or census tract**
Properties in Opportunity Zones, HUD-designated areas, or high-poverty tracts may have added steps

PHASE 3 — PROPERTY PREP: NSPIRE / HCV INSPECTION READINESS

STEP 3A — ELECTRICAL & SAFETY SYSTEMS

☐ **Smoke detector installed on every floor of the unit**
Must be functional — inspector will physically test each one; replace any unit over 10 years old

☐ **Smoke detector inside or directly adjacent to every bedroom**
Confirm with your PHA: some require inside the room, some accept the adjacent hallway

☐ **Carbon monoxide detector on every sleeping floor (within 15 ft of bedrooms)**
Required in any home with gas appliances, oil/gas heat, or an attached garage

☐ **All smoke and CO detectors tested — replace batteries in battery-powered units**
Hardwired detectors with battery backup preferred; press the test button on each one

☐ **No exposed wiring anywhere in the unit**
Exposed romex, wire nuts outside a box, or open splices = automatic fail; cap and box everything

☐ **All junction boxes covered with code-compliant cover plates**
Check attic, basement, utility closet, garage, and laundry room in addition to living spaces

☐ **GFCI outlets within 6 feet of every kitchen sink (both counter circuits)**
Test with a GFCI tester — press Test button, outlet should go dead; press Reset to restore

☐ **GFCI outlets in all bathrooms — every bathroom outlet must be GFCI protected**
Vanity outlets, near-tub outlets — all require GFCI; install or verify with tester

☐ **GFCI outlets at all exterior outlet locations**
Front porch, rear porch, garage outlets, any outdoor receptacle must be GFCI

☐ **All outlets and light switches functional — use a circuit tester on every outlet**
Dead outlets or non-working switches are a fail; trace circuit and repair before inspection

☐ **Electrical panel: all breakers labeled, no double-taps, no scorch marks or burns**
Open knockouts in the panel must be filled; panel must be accessible — no shelving in front of it

☐ **All light fixtures operational — replace every burned-out bulb before inspection**

Inspector will flip every light switch; any non-working fixture or missing bulb is a fail

STEP 3B — PLUMBING & WATER SYSTEMS☐ **Hot AND cold running water at every sink, tub, and shower**

Run each fixture for 30 seconds; hot water must reach a minimum of 110°F at fixtures

☐ **No leaks under any sink — check supply lines, P-traps, and drain connections**

Inspectors open every cabinet under every sink; even minor drips or staining = fail

☐ **All drains flow freely — test every sink, tub, and shower drain for standing water**

Use a drain snake or enzymatic cleaner before inspection; slow drains are a common fail item

☐ **All toilets flush properly and do not run continuously after flushing**

Running toilets indicate a failed flapper or fill valve; parts cost under \$15 and take 20 minutes

☐ **Water heater operational — pilot lit (gas) or element working (electric)**

Set thermostat to 120°F; above 120°F is a scalding hazard and may be flagged by inspector

☐ **Temperature & Pressure (T&P) relief valve installed on water heater**

Must be the original equipment style T&P valve with a test lever — not capped, taped, or missing

☐ **T&P discharge pipe runs downward and terminates within 6 inches of floor**

Cannot terminate upward, into a drain pan, or in any configuration that restricts flow — must point down

☐ **Test T&P valve by briefly lifting the lever — should release then reseal without dripping**

If it drips continuously after testing, replace the T&P valve before the inspection date

☐ **No cross-connections between potable water supply and any other system**

Garden hose bibs should have backflow preventers; any direct connection to irrigation needs an RPZ valve

STEP 3C — HVAC & HEATING SYSTEM☐ **Primary heating system (furnace, boiler, or heat pump) operational and cycling correctly**

System must be capable of maintaining 68°F in all habitable rooms at 0°F outdoor temperature

☐ **HVAC filter replaced — use the correct size and MERV rating for your system**

Dirty filters restrict airflow and are a visible maintenance concern; replace before every inspection

☐ **All supply vents and return air registers present, open, and unobstructed**

Missing registers, furniture blocking returns, or closed vents reduce system performance — fix all

☐ **Flue pipe for furnace and water heater properly connected and sealed at all joints**

Check the attic and utility closet for disconnected flue sections; CO poisoning risk if failed

☐ **Flue pipe vents to exterior and terminates correctly (not into an attic or crawl space)**

Improper termination is a life-safety issue; call an HVAC tech if any doubt about routing

☐ **Thermostat functional — verify heat turns on and cycles off at the set temperature**

Replace non-functional or blank-screen thermostats; a \$25 programmable thermostat is sufficient

☐ **Flexible duct (flex duct): no kinks, no disconnections, supported every 4 feet**

Check attic and crawl space; kinked flex duct reduces airflow by up to 50% and causes comfort complaints

☐ **If A/C is included in the lease or provided: must be operational**

A/C is not federally required under NSPIRE — but if it's listed in the lease, it must work

☐ **Gas supply lines: no visible corrosion; flexible connectors not longer than 6 feet**

If you smell gas anywhere in the unit — stop everything and call the gas company immediately

STEP 3D — WINDOWS, DOORS & STRUCTURAL ELEMENTS☐ **Every window opens, closes, latches, and stays open without being propped**

Broken sash cords, painted-shut frames, missing latches, or swollen sashes = fail; repair all

☐ **No cracked, broken, or missing window glass panes anywhere in the unit**

Even hairline cracks are a fail — replace all damaged glazing before the inspection date

☐ **All windows have working locks / latches that hold securely**

Inspect every sash; loose or broken window hardware is inexpensive to replace

☐ **Every exterior door closes fully, latches, and locks with a keyed deadbolt**

Door frame must be solid; deadbolts must throw fully; weather stripping should seal the gap

☐ **Every bedroom door closes fully, latches, and operates without sticking**

Bedroom doors provide egress and fire protection; warped or sticking doors must be planed or replaced

☐ **Every bathroom door closes and provides privacy via interior latch or lock**

A bathroom door that won't latch is a common and easily-fixed fail item

☐ **No holes, gouges, or large damage in any interior wall or ceiling surface**

Patch and paint all drywall holes, no matter how small — every visible hole is a potential fail

☐ **No peeling, flaking, or chipping paint anywhere — interior or exterior surfaces**

Pre-1978 homes: chipping paint may be lead-based; remediate per EPA RRP rules before inspection

☐ **No water staining, mold, or mildew on any wall, ceiling, or floor surface**

Staining indicates an active or past moisture problem; find and fix the source before patching

☐ **All flooring secure — no loose carpet edges, buckling laminate, or uneven thresholds**

Trip hazard items include lifted carpet tack strips, loose tile, and raised transition strips

☐ **Stairway handrails: required when 4 or more risers — must be graspable and firmly secured**

Wobbly railings must be anchored; open-baluster railings must have no gaps greater than 4 inches

STEP 3E — KITCHEN☐ **All stove/range burners operational — test every burner and the oven**

If the stove is listed in the lease it must work; replace faulty elements or ignitors before inspection

☐ **Oven heats to temperature — use an oven thermometer to verify**

A stove that "mostly works" with one bad burner or a broken oven door is a fail

☐ **Range hood / exhaust fan operational — cleans filters or replaces if grease-clogged**

Fan must move air; confirm it actually exhausts and isn't just recirculating if your PHA requires exterior vent

☐ **If refrigerator is included in the lease: must cool and all door gaskets must seal**

Confirm with your PHA whether a refrigerator is required — this varies; if provided, it must function

☐ **All cabinet doors and drawers open and close fully — hinges and slides intact**

Broken hinges are a \$2 fix that takes 10 minutes; inspector will open every cabinet door

☐ **No holes or gaps in the cabinet base under the kitchen sink**

Pest entry points under the sink must be sealed with steel wool and caulk before inspection

☐ **Countertops intact — no severely damaged laminate, sharp edges, or burn damage**

Counters that cannot be safely used without cutting hands must be replaced or refinished

STEP 3F — BATHROOMS

☐ **Exhaust fan operational and vents to the exterior of the building**

A fan venting into the attic is a moisture and mold risk — re-route to exterior or install a new unit

☐ **No deteriorated, missing, or moldy caulk at tub and shower surrounds**

Gaps in caulk allow water behind tile; remove all old caulk, clean surface, re-caulk before inspection

☐ **Tile grout intact — no missing or severely cracked grout lines in wet areas**

Missing grout in the shower allows water behind the tile; regrout or replace affected sections

☐ **Toilet secure to floor — no rocking or movement when sat upon**

A rocking toilet indicates a failed wax ring or damaged floor flange; repair before inspection

☐ **Adequate ventilation in every bathroom — operable window or working exhaust fan required**

Bathrooms without windows must have a working exhaust fan; this is non-negotiable under NSPIRE

STEP 3G — EXTERIOR & SITE

☐ **Foundation: no major visible cracks, settlement gaps, or water intrusion at the base**

Hairline cracks may be acceptable; horizontal cracks in block foundations are serious — consult engineer

☐ **Exterior walls: no significant holes, rotted wood siding, or gaps into the wall cavity**

Check all wood trim, window sills, and door frames with a screwdriver; soft wood = rot = fail

☐ **Roof: no visible missing shingles, sagging ridgeline, or exposed decking from ground level**

Inspector observes the roof from the ground; material failures visible from street are flagged

☐ **Gutters: attached, not pulling from fascia, draining freely with no standing water**

Clogged gutters cause overflow that damages the fascia and foundation; clean before inspection

☐ **Downspouts: extend at least 6 inches away from the foundation**

Use splash blocks or downspout extensions; water pooling against the foundation is a long-term risk

☐ **Site grading: ground slopes away from foundation on all sides**

Add topsoil and slope away if water currently drains toward the house

☐ **All exterior steps and porches structurally sound — no soft spots, rot, or loose boards**

Handrails required on any exterior stair with 4 or more risers; must be secure and graspable

☐ **No significant trip hazards in driveway, walkways, or path to entry door**

Heaved concrete slabs, large cracks, or missing sections that create lips over 1/2" must be addressed

☐ **House address numbers visible from the street**

Required for emergency services access; must be at least 3" tall in a contrasting color

☐ **Pest entry points on exterior sealed — gaps around pipes, foundation cracks, uncapped vents**

Seal all utility penetrations through foundation and siding; chimney and attic vents need mesh screens

PHASE 4 — FINDING & PLACING YOUR FIRST HCV TENANT

STEP 4 — VOUCHER VERIFICATION & TENANT SCREENING

- ☐ **Request a copy of the prospective tenant's Housing Choice Voucher before proceeding**
Verify: voucher is not expired, bedroom size matches your unit, issuing PHA covers your address
- ☐ **Confirm the voucher bedroom size matches your unit exactly**
A 3BR voucher holder can only occupy a 3BR unit; PHA will reject the RFTA if sizes do not match
- ☐ **Confirm your rent does not exceed the PHA Payment Standard for this unit size and zip code**
Payment Standard = the maximum HAP; your rent must be at or below this threshold
- ☐ **Verify portability if tenant is moving in from a different PHA jurisdiction**
Out-of-jurisdiction vouchers require a portability transfer; contact receiving PHA to confirm accepted
- ☐ **Run your standard tenant screening: background check, eviction history, credit report**
You may screen HCV applicants the same as any applicant; cannot reject based solely on voucher status
- ☐ **Verify tenant can afford their rent portion — HAP + tenant portion = your total rent**
HUD limits the tenant's share to no more than 40% of their adjusted monthly income at initial lease-up
- ☐ **Contact the applicant's previous landlord for a reference**
Ask specifically: any lease violations, property condition at move-out, would you rent to them again?

STEP 5 — RFTA SUBMISSION & INSPECTION SCHEDULING

- ☐ **Complete the Request for Tenancy Approval (RFTA) with the tenant — both parties sign**
RFTA forms are provided by your PHA; this document initiates the inspection and approval process
- ☐ **Enter the correct rent amount and utility responsibility assignment on the RFTA**
Utilities paid by landlord vs. tenant directly affects the HAP calculation — be precise
- ☐ **Submit the signed RFTA to the PHA and obtain a case number or written confirmation**
Keep a copy; submission date starts the clock on processing time
- ☐ **Confirm the HCV inspection appointment with the PHA scheduler**
Be present at the inspection or send an authorized representative who can answer questions
- ☐ **Complete a final walk-through using Steps 3A–3G before the inspection date**
One failed item triggers a re-inspection; re-inspections delay move-in and your first HAP payment
- ☐ **Pass the HCV inspection — receive written results from the PHA inspector**
For any failed items: repair within PHA's deadline and request re-inspection in writing immediately
- ☐ **Sign the Housing Assistance Payment (HAP) contract with the PHA**
Do NOT allow tenant to move in before the HAP contract is signed — this is your legal payment guarantee

PHASE 5 — LEASE EXECUTION & MOVE-IN

STEP 6 — LEASE & MOVE-IN DOCUMENTATION

- ☐ **Execute your standard lease agreement with the tenant**
Include all terms: rent amount, due date, late fees, maintenance process, and house rules
- ☐ **Attach the HUD-required Section 8 lease addendum (provided by your PHA)**
This addendum is federally required, cannot be modified, and must be attached to your standard lease
- ☐ **Confirm tenant rent portion, due date, and payment method in writing**
HAP is paid by PHA on the 1st; tenant pays their portion separately — document the exact dollar amount

- ☐ **Collect the security deposit from the tenant before move-in**
HAP does not cover the deposit; most PHAs cap the security deposit at one month's rent
- ☐ **Document all utilities the tenant is responsible for and confirm transfer of accounts**
Tenant must transfer electric, gas, water accounts into their name before move-in if they are responsible
- ☐ **Conduct the move-in inspection walkthrough with the tenant present**
Walk every room together; note all pre-existing conditions in writing on the inspection form
- ☐ **Take at least 50–100 date/time stamped photos of every room, wall, floor, and appliance**
Upload immediately to cloud storage in a dated folder; these are your primary move-out protection
- ☐ **Record a narrated video walkthrough of the entire unit at move-in**
"This scratch on the bathroom door was pre-existing..." — video with narration is powerful evidence
- ☐ **Have tenant sign the move-in inspection form — provide tenant a copy**
A signed inspection form eliminates most security deposit disputes at move-out
- ☐ **Provide tenant with copy of lease, HAP amount, utility responsibility summary**
Also provide: emergency maintenance phone number, trash pickup schedule, and parking rules
- ☐ **Provide two complete sets of keys for all exterior doors and the mailbox**
Include a key receipt in the lease; missing keys at move-out = deduction from security deposit

PHASE 6 — ONGOING COMPLIANCE & ANNUAL RE-INSPECTION

STEP 7 — ANNUAL RE-INSPECTION PREPARATION

Begin this prep 60 days before your expected re-inspection date. PHA will provide written notice.

- ☐ **Re-run Steps 3A–3G using this full checklist 60 days before re-inspection**
Items that passed at move-in deteriorate over time: detector batteries, window hardware, door latches
- ☐ **Test all smoke and CO detectors — replace batteries or replace units over 10 years old**
Many PHAs flag a dead detector as an immediate fail requiring same-day correction — don't risk it
- ☐ **Inspect all window latches — tighten screws or replace any latch that no longer holds securely**
Window hardware loosens with regular use; a loose latch is a quick fix but a real fail item
- ☐ **Test all exterior door locks and deadbolts — deadbolt must throw fully without sticking**
Lubricate with graphite dry lubricant (not WD-40); replace lock hardware that is worn or stiff
- ☐ **Check under every sink for new leaks, soft cabinet floors, rust, or pest evidence**
Year-over-year moisture leads to rotted cabinet bottoms and mold growth; repair early to prevent spread
- ☐ **Inspect all interior and exterior painted surfaces for new peeling or flaking**
Touch up all affected areas immediately; pre-1978 homes require lead-safe work practices
- ☐ **Replace HVAC filter and test heating/cooling to confirm full seasonal operation**
A non-functional heating system at re-inspection is a life-safety fail — service annually
- ☐ **Walk the full exterior: gutters, downspouts, steps, handrails, address numbers**
Winter weather commonly damages gutters, fascia, and steps; inspect every spring before re-inspection season
- ☐ **Document all repairs made since last inspection — save receipts, photos, and contractor invoices**
Organized maintenance records support ongoing compliance, protect your HAP contract, and document your investment

KEY RESOURCES

Find your PHA: hud.gov/program_offices/public_indian_housing/programs/hcv
Fair Market Rents: huduser.gov/portal/datasets/fmr.html
NSPIRE Standards: hud.gov/program_offices/public_indian_housing/reac/nspire
EPA Lead Paint (RRP): epa.gov/lead/renovation-repair-and-painting-program